conscious effort was made to diversify business and today, GE's contribution is only around 1.5 per cent.

Ratan took the right decision and at the right time, Chandrasekaran says. His judgement to only list in India first was laudable too. When interviewed, Hussain could barely conceal his delight at having been involved in the process and remembered that the seminal event happened under his watch.

The discussions to list TCS had also resurrected an earlier discussion on the listing of Tata Sons. 'Many advised Ratan to take Tata Sons public,' recalls Hussain. Ratan was hounded by investment bankers who built various enticing scenarios, hoping to make it happen. During one meeting of Tata Sons in the early 2000s, a decision was even taken to take the holding company public, says the former finance director. '[But] Ratan Tata kept his counsel close to his chest'; he did not say anything in favour of it, reveals Hussain. That was signature Ratan.

The decision they had taken, however, gave many of the Tata doyens sleepless nights. And by morning, they had changed their minds. Soonawala and Hussain led the move for a rethink. It was a question of losing control over many companies. If the parent company was listed, then it would lose the freedom to take some important decisions regarding the companies under it. There would be no freedom to raise the stake of Tata Sons in the group companies, for instance. Soonawala was particularly fearful that in such an eventuality, the Tatas would lose control over the conglomerate. The plan was not pursued any further. And not to act on the proposal to list Tata Sons, though seldom spoken about, would be the single most important decision, one of colossal significance, that Ratan took and conversely, did not take, as chairman, Tata Sons.

After the listing, Ratan began paying more attention to TCS. His subtle nudging of the company, if anything, became more frequent. The company's value was now virtually being determined daily by the markets and the crown jewel of the group had a reputation to safeguard. Ratan challenged the TCS leadership by asking, 'Why is somebody else better than you?' It was done in an unobtrusive manner, recalls Chandrasekaran. But it was enough to light the fire in their bellies to strive better, to make them introspect whether they had reached the pinnacle of their achievement. That opened the door to greater performance.